

Yesterday we began to examine how capitalism operates: a form of semantic manipulation, that is how it works on the major meaning and symbols that characterise and shape our experience.

We discussed what company define as a merit, while today we'll also try to address merit, but from the dark side of merit, which is sacrifice. This is a Greek term widely used by religions, but also by the job world and economy. Company's policies are changing the meaning of this world.

In arcanic societies, sacrifices consisted on the harvest, and any kind of tribute offered to divinity. By rule, all these goods, belonged to the priestly order. Thanks to these sacrifices, the priest lived very well. There is an economic idea within the concept of sacrifice, as people believed they could control God's will for their own benefit.

Unlike pagan priests, biblical prophets did not appreciate sacrifice, as offering things to Gods was similar to offering things to pagan idols. They instead claimed a salvation that does not pass through sacrifices, but through grace. If we think about the word "gratiis", it means "through grace".

On one side there are sacrifices that have value only if they're worth something economically. Sacrifices are more perfect if it's more useful for God, and more useless for human. The perfect sacrifice is the holocaust (???), with animals being fully burned in order to be delivered completely to God, and nothing remains to humans.

In many religious traditions, sacrifice represent a kind of currency, in this double entry relationship between the believer and the divine.

If on one hand the believer is happy to acquire merits and compensate for guilts through an act of sacrifice, in the other hand the administrators of religion gain significant economical advantages and control, by fueling this kind of exchange. Christianity had to struggle in its early stages to proclaim a religion entirely based on gratuity and grace. As soon as Christianity stopped to struggle, the idolatry temptation promptly returned (??).

What happens with the advent of modernity? Sacrifice seems to disappear, but it does not. On the contrary, it became one of the keywords in the lexicon of the new sacred, inaugurated by global corporations. To understand this corporate universe, we can refer to its more superficial aspect, like the presence of coaches, who're trying to imitate the original spirital father, or the use of words borrowed from religious languages like "mission", "vocation", etc.

Another interesting characteristic of this form of religion is the relationship they developed with the old and new, elderly and young.

On the one hand we can see a demonisation of the old seen as something or someone already consumed, rather than a bearer of memory and knowledge. The past is denied as a residue to be discarded, something already outdated and useless for the present.

Mirroring this rejection of the old, there is a voracious appetite for what is new and youth. Idolatrous cults worship youth to consume it and offer it as a sacrifice. Workers in large corporations are required to sacrifice time from social and family life, and withdraw time from future projects. Work has always involved effort, sweat and sacrifice. But the sacrifice within the 20th century work culture was transparent, both in who made the sacrifice and who received it.

The labor movement had managed to contain it within political limits, and when it exceeded those limits, the legal system reacted, punishing it.

We've always known that behind much work there are distant Gods, living off the income of the ones sacrificed. These sacrifice were transparent to us, we were aware of them, and we fought to eliminate these injustice, creating documents like Constitution in support of this purpose. If it's true that every empires tries to manipulate the world it inherits, today the semantic world of capitalism attempts to present the surplus of sacrifice as a form of voluntary gift. We are more exploited than before by anonymous distant Gods, and by wealthy technopharaons, but we're also expected to be happy about our sacrifices, and internalise them as gifts.

Sacrifices become an act of grace and worship, hoping for the favour of the Gods. Conversevely, those who refuse to make these sacrifices, and wish to reserve the boundary between private and work life, remain outside the circle of the chosen, and often develop deep feelings of guilt for being losers, failed to give what they should.

Offering can never extinguish the sacrifices debt, that remained unpaid, despite sacrifices.

In these companies, the more and time we give, the more are demanded, until we exhaust our offerings. Management will then associate to us the appropriate coach to restart.

Gift has been transformed into debt, just like in ancient idolatries. The idol does not make sacrifice, it only receives sacrifices from the believers. The company therefore is always on the creditor side, with no reciprocal debt towards its workers. They feel no obligation for recognition of sacrifices received by workers. Corporations dissolve and move to tax heavens, laying off workers, and in the worst case scenario they repay a lifetime of sacrifices with a small amount of money.

In ancient cults, sacrifices had to involve something living, so animals, children, virgins or sacred plants were offered to the Gods, never inanimate objects. The new Gods also continued to demand for sacrifices, asking for young life and returning money for it. The first sacrificial victims are the managers themselves, who're both priests and sacrifices of the system.

Kings and priests demand for the first and best fruits from the harvest, taking the best part for them. What is the difference between present and gifts? We consider the present as "regalo", while gift is "dono". For "regalo" we can find two roots: the first is from "rex", meaning "king", so it was those present offered to powerful elements of the society to withdraw their favours. It also comes from "res", so it means "thing", must be an object. This idea of "regalo" is not for free, as it wants something back. The gift does not want anything in return, and can be a thing or not, and can have the material part not being crucial, with the important thing being the symbolic value.

Unlike presents, which are requested by Kings, hierarchy have free gifts not allowed with their goals, as they cannot be controlled. Trying to control gifts into something similar is the visible ? of the hierarchy, which tries to strip the gift of its free dimension.

Let's now dive deeper in the idea of gifts and gratuity. Unlike sacrifice, gratuity is a great word of religion, but not a word of idolatries and capitalism. Gratuity is the main taboo of capitalism, seen as great danger. Its free gift is allowed to circulate freely, it would infect the system with poison ("gift" in german means poison), leading capitalism to its death, or to a radical transformation.

Community have to learn and manage human violent impulses, and avoid self destruction. The creation of taboos belongs to the tools used to regulate and control communities. Taboos have served this function for millenia, but generating discrimination and persecution towards those who become its objects.

Taboo is something to be avoided in one hand, something that one must be protected from, and even the word associated must not be spoken and pronounced. Yet, the object of the taboo, while it's perceived as frightening and sacry, it provokes powerful attraction, precisely because of the prohibition. The taboo concern a desire that is both strong but dangerous for the survival of the community. Taboos can be applied to people, words, and animals. They share a dual characteristic: they must not be touched, but they cannot be eliminated, as the goal of a taboo management is not the disappearance of the taboo object. If it vanished, the boundary of what is forbidden would vanish as well. By marking the boundary, the taboo also defines the good part of the community. By setting a limit, it creates a space, and without it the community would lose its boundaries, and become

contaminated by what is sought to avoid.

We can understand capitalism by considering gratuity as its taboo.

Let's consider three market communities, all based on hierarchy and gift.

Hierarchy managed power, while gift regulated reciprocity within families, clans and communities. Only in the temple hierarchy and gift intercepts, and outside remains separated. Markets arise from the elimination of gifts. At the same time, the elimination of gift did not eliminate hierarchy as well. Market economies intensify hierarchies. The death of gift as exalted hierarchy. Even when it appears in flat organizations, it's just a fake.

Gratuity must not be profaned, but must remain visible and well displayed, being surveilled. Its boundary coincides with the limit of the market itself. The land of gratuity begins when the land of incentives ???. Languages and behaviours, once we enter into our office, must be shaken off, and the mentality of gratuity and gift with it.

Companies have specific days and heavens a ritual where the taboo object must be touched, sacrificed and consumed in order to appropriate of its mysterious power. During corporate convention, the gift is invoked only to be returned the next to its untouchable tabernacle, confined in its sacred space. Companies organize initiatives to donate small amount of money to organizations, ...

This domesticated weakness control gifts, imitating the real gift in order to neutralise them. This is the culture of homeopathic gift. Homeopathy is the idea according to which like is cured by like. For instance, if we get burned we put a warm piece of cloth. Also metaphorically, this idea works. "Invidia" comes from "in-video", looking inside (??).

Homeopathic gifts practices aim to immunise against an evil by symbolically using the same evil, as if two negatives multiplied together becomes positive.

This mechanism of homeopathic gifts is particularly rooted. Large capitalist institutions attempt to immunize itself against the true ? of gifts.

It introduces into the system doses of gifts, replacing the big and real gifts, with gadgets, donations, which are all immunisation practices, seeming to function well in our system.

Instead of questioning the amount of pollution produced by industries, companies promise to plant new trees. Instead of questioning corporate property life, and distribution of wealth, a small amount is donated. instead of creating working conditions where workers can express their maximum, we use volunteering.

On the consumption side, we see the invasion of sales, discounts.

While gift is given for free, present is given for a fee, so there is something economic in its root. If companies embraced the concept of gift, they would have

to manage people capable of actions that cannot be controlled easily, as people are genuinely free. They would have to deal with workers driven by their motivation, so with more chaos.

This confusion is hated by management, which discourages by making the boundary of the taboo, preventing gratuity from operating within the corporate domain.

In order to avoid the risks of the gifts, corporate culture do everything possible to transform the gift into contracts. In this way, the taboo of gratuity and straightened every day.

In conclusion, markets protect themselves from gratuity in order to protect themselves from their death. True gifts call for equality and reciprocity, and in this way hierarchy would become fraternable, with power becoming fragile.

Strong bonds are the great enemies of capitalism firms, immunising culture. They are unpronounceable taboo words. Communities nevertheless continue to live and rise, as many workers violate the taboo of gratuity, bearing all the consequences, with individuals who cannot help but give. It's on this gap that the community bond rest, allowing us to recognize that the "munus" ("cum-munus", community) is not merely the set of individual who come together to fill roles and exchange goods and services, but to give one another something free and gratuitous.